

Postmodernism in Education

Marek Tesar, University of Auckland, Andrew Gibbons, Auckland University of Technology, Sonja Arndt, University of Melbourne, and Nina Hood, University of Auckland

<https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190264093.013.1269>

Published online: 26 May 2021

Summary

The period of postmodernism refers to a diverse set of ideas, practices, and disciplines that came to prominence in the later 20th century. It is the overarching philosophical project that responds to and critiques the principles of modernity and challenges the established ways of thinking. It opposes the ideas that it is possible to rationalize life through narrow, singular disciplinary thinking or through the establishment of a universal truth and grand narratives that strive for the value-neutral homogeneity that defined Enlightenment thinking. Postmodernism questions ontological, epistemological, and ethical conventions, and it opens up possibilities for multiple discourses and accepting marginalized and minority thoughts and practices. Openness to diversity is a key outcome of the multiplicities arising in postmodernity across a range of fields, including, among others, art, education, philosophy, architecture, and economics. Through its rejection of the totalizing effects of metanarratives and their intentions to achieve universal truths, goals, outcomes, and sameness, the postmodern condition opens an ethical responsibility toward otherness, to allow for diversity, and thus to elevate those who have been subjugated or marginalized in modernity. Postmodernism has been playing a significant role in what sometimes is termed the equity approach in education. While postmodernism may be eventually overtaken by other “posts”—post-qualitative, post-truth, post-digital—it still remains an important part of philosophy of education scholarship and broader understandings and conceptualizations of education.

Keywords: postmodernism, art, education, philosophy, Derrida, Foucault, Lyotard

Subjects: Educational Theories and Philosophies

An Overview of Postmodernism

Postmodernism is a broad movement of various ideas, fields, and disciplines that emerged during the second half of the 20th century, marking a particular departure from modernity. It is more readily defined as the era following the modernist tradition and pathway rather than a unifying set of ideas. As such, Postmodernism critiques the rule of modernity, and the enlightenment and its rationality, as well as epistemological claims towards power, truth, science, and structure being conditioned by the state of society, and instead embraces an overarching pluralism. In the philosophy of education, these ideas have been present since the 1960s, however, they would not be broadly incorporated into scholarship till the early 1980s. Postmodernity (i.e., postmodern era or culture) seeks to make sense of the time and era in which we live, while postmodern theory, or postmodernism, critiques the eras—both modernity and postmodernity. These critiques are critical to our condition; for example, thinkers critique performativity, linear thinking, singularities, disciplines, and society. Postmodernism distances itself from and calls into a

question the project of modernity. This article traverses areas of art, philosophy of education, critiques, and main philosophical personas that have defined the movement, while also charting the future of postmodern thinking (see also, for instance, Peters et al., 2018, 2020). In doing so, we recognize the diverse fields that postmodernism has influenced and attempt to demonstrate some of the links between some of these fields, particularly art and philosophy, and education. We further attempt to capture the complexity and multiplicity of postmodernism by focusing on some of the leading postmodern thinkers, whose work, while grounded in the Western tradition, was seminal to the development of postmodern thinking and scholarship.

Postmodernism in Art

Postmodernism first manifested in the arts in the late 1950s—although some point to the Dadaists in the 1910s and their ridiculing of the art establishment as the antecedents of Postmodernism. It is these early antecedents of postmodernism in the arts, long before the term was used in the literature in the 1970s, that makes a discussion of postmodernism in art relevant. That is, postmodernism in art provides a tangible demonstration of some of the seminal ideas informing this era. The term “postmodernism” typically is used to refer to art produced from the 1960s, beginning with pop art, although some historians of art suggest Jasper Johns should be considered the first postmodern artist (Bochner, 2008). The term was in wide circulation in art circles by the 1970s—therefore pre-empting its use in the philosophy of education.

Postmodernism in art can be understood as a reaction against modernism (approximately 1860s–1950s) and in particular the final high modern period with its apolitical and formalist focus. Postmodernism rejects the prevailing utopian idealism and focus on art’s aestheticism—so-called art for art’s sake—that define much of the art from the modern period. It further rejects the grand narratives of technological progress and positivity, as well as Western superiority and progress that underpinned the modern period.

Postmodernism in art largely defies a single definition, in part because central to its purpose was the rejection of grand narratives or universal truths. Consequently, a range of art styles and movements fall under the broader label of postmodernism—pop art, feminist art, installation and performance art, conceptual art, neo-expressionism, and the young British artists. Central to postmodernism in art was a collapse of the distinction between high art and low art and more broadly between high culture and low culture. However, it should be noted that the antecedents of these ideas do feature in artists of the modernist period, perhaps most notably the Dadaists. There is a freedom in subject, in aesthetic, and in the use of materials in postmodernism. The inclusion of irony and the playful treatment of an often-fragmented subject feature heavily in the art (and architecture) of this time. Furthermore, postmodernism in art, in keeping with postmodern philosophy, rejects a single reading of a “work” of art, but rather conceptualizes the artwork as a “text” with multiple, evolving meanings.

Postmodernism in art also is marked by a different subjective positioning of the artist. There was a shift away from the inward focus of modernism to a more outward focus, with the postmodern artist contributing to social and political debates and dialogues. As postmodernist critic Andreas Huyssen commented: “If pop art has drawn our attention the imagery of daily life, demanding that the separation of high and low be eliminated, then today it is the task of the artist to break out of art’s tower and contribute to a change of everyday” (Huyssen, 1986, pp. 17–18). There were many ways that this challenging and questioning manifested. Subject matter played some role;

however, it primarily was achieved through the artists' use of materials and, in, particular, a combining of styles and media, and the utilization of low art forms alongside and in high art contexts. For example, U.S. feminist Judy Chicago's *The Dinner Party* (1974–1979) utilized traditional women's arts and crafts materials, such as embroidery and painted porcelain, alongside motifs of vulvas to honor thirty-nine prominent women from history. Here, the materials came together using a range of symbolic motifs to speak directly to feminist issues in contemporary society. Yet the complexity of the work defies a single interpretation, instead encouraging multiple readings and rereadings. These discourses performed in art went on to become prevalent in education and philosophy.

Postmodernism in Philosophy

Similar to art, it is difficult to think of postmodernism without first considering modernity as a concept in philosophy, a project, and a historical period. As a project, modernity describes the time of the Enlightenment. It represents “a view of the world as knowable and ordered” (Dahlberg et al., 2013, p. 21), which upholds as its key aims the freedom and enrichment of human life through the application of the advancements of the Enlightenment. Arising during the 17th and 18th centuries, the age and views of modernity established beliefs such as that there is a universal truth with a knowable, linear way of progressing toward that truth. Achieving its aim of social, political, and cultural freedom depended on the universal belief that all human beings were capable of following standardized linear pathways to one truth, of thinking rationally, and of living an ordered, predictable life. A modern view on knowledge is that knowledge can be achieved as a result of rational thought, that it is value free, universal, and true. The knowing individual in modernity is an important component of the future of society, that ostensibly strives toward equality, with little regard for diversities of gender, histories, culture, race, or context. In this society, science and reason are responsible for delivering the answers to questions of human importance. They are simultaneously seen as leading society to its aims of freedom and progress and as underlying oppressive social and political regimes such as traditional Marxism, war, and oppression (Best & Kellner, 1991).

Postmodernism is then the overarching philosophical project that responds to and critiques the principles of modernity. It opposes the idea that it is possible to rationalize life through narrow, singular disciplinary thinking or through the establishment of a universal truth and metanarratives that strive for value-neutral homogeneity that defined Enlightenment thinking. Lather (1991) points to the development of the postmodern turn as a growing skepticism about modernity, especially its “inability to comprehend and accommodate human diversity, complexity and contingency” and the expectation that they could be ordered “out of existence” (p. 88). Postmodernity is a response to the impossible goals of universal uniformity, in the strived for singular truth, achievable knowledge, and thought, that is, the unachievable goal of modernity.

Postmodernity spans fields and disciplines as broad and all-encompassing as history, culture, art, architecture, politics, and society; and it characterizes responses to the tensions arising from war, genocide, or totalitarian regimes, which stem from the subjugation of all but particular elevated classes, cultures, religions, or belief systems. Postmodernity pushes beyond binary classifications and singular truths to make way for multiplicities, diverse perspectives, and heterogeneous realities. In a time of increased globalization, diversity, and elevation of cultural

otherness, postmodernism makes way in philosophy for recognitions of multiple ways of knowing and being, where there is no one right way. Such a condition simultaneously makes way for conceptions of chaos and uncertainty; for epistemic crises (Gasparatou, 2018); for poststructural philosophers such as Foucault, Lyotard, Deleuze, Kristeva, and Derrida; for postcolonialist critiques of ongoing colonizing practices; and other “post” philosophies that create the spaces for renewed questioning and epistemic openness to revolutionary understandings of society, bodies, feminisms, and politics. Postmodernism enabled the rise of post-qualitative philosophies and methodologies (Tesar, 2021) and philosophy as a method (Tesar, 2020).

Postmodern thought is most commonly seen as emerging from French philosophical traditions, particularly in “the aftermath of structuralism and poststructuralism” (West, 2010, p. 218). While it is difficult to define, a clear statement of postmodernity is Lyotard’s *The Postmodern Condition*, where instead of labeling postmodernism as a particular state, it is presented as a condition that is opposed to capitalism. The “post” element gives the term, or condition, two angles. On the one hand, postmodernism manifests as a critique of modernity. In this sense postmodernism is framed as an attack on humanist theories, on the logical thinking implied in rationalism, and on Enlightenment principles, on which Eurocentric, philosophical understandings long relied. Some postmodern questioning of modern grand narratives emerged in Foucault’s advancements of new concepts of theories on power, politics, and ethics; in Baudrillard’s proposed radical semiurgy arising from a proliferation of signs that would produce “new forms of society, culture, experience, and subjectivity” (Best & Kellner, 1991, p. 27); in Lyotard’s seminal proclamation that the postmodern condition “marks the end of the grand narratives and hopes of modernity and the impossibility of continuing with the totalizing social theories and revolutionary politics of the past” (p. 27); in Deleuze and Guattari’s introduction of schizoanalysis and rhizomatics as a way to counteract the “repressive territorializations of desire throughout society and everyday life” and to seek possible “lines of escape” (2013, p. 27); and in Laclau and Mouffe’s radical (Best & Kellner, 1991) democratic critique of modern political theory, including modern Marxism. On the other hand, and together with this approach, postmodernism can also be seen as depending on and merely altering, rather than ending, modernity.

The postmodern condition in Continental philosophy was accompanied by a wide-ranging skepticism. Driven by the desire to avoid grand narratives, it led to skepticism about histories and beliefs in God, for example in Nietzsche (West, 2010). Beyond the French context, postmodern critiques opened up to the divergences beyond Western philosophical ideals and dominance to include non-Western thought and othernesses. Previously held truths were challenged, and the assumed superiority, power, and hierarchies became troubled in the call for reconstructions of traditional philosophy and social theory. While postmodernism in philosophy includes poststructuralism and ranges from the critique of theoretical constructs and philosophies of modernity, any description of postmodernism in philosophy must remain both as open and as nuanced as its act and effect, in keeping with Lyotard’s (1984) “incredulity towards metanarratives” (p. xxiv). Furthermore, postmodernism has opened possibilities to think differently about the archives (Tesar & Arndt, 2019) via thinkers such as Foucault, Derrida, and Lyotard, who have dedicated sections in this chapter.

Postmodernism in Education

Postmodern perspectives bring to education an openness to diversity and complexity that moves beyond a critique of narrow scientific knowledge. It brings to the fore the much more complex realities of social, cultural, and political contexts and their influences on educational institutions, practices, and settings. On the one hand, postmodernism in education rejects modernity and singularity outright, and, on the other hand, it incorporates and moves on from grand scale hierarchies. In its various forms and presentations, the postmodern disruption of the metanarratives that Lyotard critiques in *The Postmodern Condition* is responsible for the recognition of diverse approaches, practices, knowledges, and agency within the field of education. It made and continues to make possible approaches that ask questions rather than tell truths, allowing multiple forms of governance, rather than one singular ruling or ruler, or a dominant policymaker or way of operating. The postmodern shift reveals the complications and ethical concerns inherent in the expectation of a singular all-encompassing truth, superiority, domination, and power of modernist approaches to education (Bauman, 1991).

A postmodern framing of education responds to what Bauman (2009) has called a “liquid” modernity. In other words, it is the fluidity that counteracts the educational focus on short-term commitments, goals, and lack of stability of neoliberal ideologies. The approaches that fall within a postmodern framing are those that can reconnect with the local and with more than the economic. They provoke questioning within education systems that remain widely and internationally focused on globalization and marketization, where economic goals reign supreme, and education systems are oversaturated with unprocessable information and lack a deep understanding of the complexities of their own local knowledges. The domination of a global precarity and economic interdependency raise the crucial role of the poststructural, post-qualitative, and postcolonial orientations of postmodernity through which future citizens, as well as their contributions to society and the planet, might respond to and deal with their futures more broadly. Postmodern perspectives in education thus offer a challenge to contemporary neoliberal, or liquid modern, influences on educational policy.

Multiple philosophical and theoretical positionings reflect postmodern perspectives in educational ideologies in responses to modernist benchmarks and local and international expectations that continue to elevate particular developmental, scientific truths and decontextualised outcomes as universal achievement goals. These positionings reflect a range of postmodernisms, rather than one postmodernism, as Burbules (2010) has suggested, leading to the notion of the condition or project of postmodernity, being viewed, like the development of the educational subject and field, as ongoing constructions that are diverse and continually evolving. In educational settings they can play out through the use of critical and creative thinking strategies in curricula, inculcating the challenge of diverse thinking, scholarship, and practices focused on introducing philosophical thought, critique, and argument into schools (Lipman, 2003). Such engagements are expected to facilitate postmodern recognition of diverse validities, multiple realities, views and perspectives, and the use of reasoning to gain deeper insights, rather than for the purposes, as in modernity, of gaining power over, dominating, or negating divergent perspectives or standpoints. Views on the pluralities of postmodernism in education are evident in postmodern perspectives previously written about, for example, in Peters (2011) on the work of Derrida, Foucault, Lyotard, and Deleuze, as well as on their mentors Nietzsche and Heidegger, in

relation to knowledge, education, the body and critical studies of education. These pluralities of postmodernism create a critical grounding in other geographical and indigenous philosophies and educational futures (Stewart et al., 2017).

In education the postmodernist project is a crucial disruptive force in the multiple and complex layers of modernist discourses and controls. Within the emergence of “post” philosophies and post-qualitative approaches, postmodernism in educational research pushes against the reification of scientific research, which continues to build on the essence of measurability, reliability, and generalizability, in funding and advancement policies in educational policy and academia. The postmodern goal of disrupting the status quo, of unsettling what is knowable, creates uncertainty and offers spaces in which the new can emerge (Lather, 2017). The rejection by postmodern philosophies of dominating, marginalizing policies is critical in the realm of educational research to recognize the multiplicities of realities, paradigms, methods, and voices and to allow for diverse and complex approaches beyond binary, colonizing, singular ways of knowing and being. Concerns such as issues of Indigenous disadvantage, ongoing racisms in education, and the marginalization of refugee and migrant populations depend on postmodern openness. The postmodern condition not only makes space for the theoretical and philosophical disruptions of hierarchies and dominance, it also goes further to represent the discursive space in which histories, traditions, curricula—beyond Western diversities—subject formation, and identity find a place. However, it is critical that this condition works alongside modernist views on education, enhancing, rather than taking over, the potential simplicity of rules, toolkits, universalized manuals, and measuring scales.

Key Postmodern Concepts for Education

Diversity: An openness to diversity is a key outcome of the multiplicities arising in postmodernity. Through its rejection of the totalizing effects of metanarratives or grand narratives and their intentions to achieve universal truths, goals, outcomes, and sameness, the postmodern condition opens up to the ethical responsibility toward otherness, to allow for diversity, and thus to elevate those who have been subjugated or marginalized in modernity (West, 2010).

Essentialism: Often seen as a both/and rather than an either/or condition, postmodernism is a critique of ontological and epistemological essentialism. It offers inroads for diverse conceptualizations of histories, knowledges, truths, realities, cultures, and beings, especially as a political motivation to elevate those who have been marginalized (McQueen & McQueen, 2010). Founded in Sartre’s denial of the essence of a person, in his dictum that human existence precedes human essence, opens further to the recognition that humans are shaped by their context, experiences, histories, and realities, supporting a postmodern attitude of critique of essentialist thought.

Metanarratives/grand narratives: The postmodern condition in recent times is commonly seen as abiding by Lyotard’s rejection of the credulity of metanarratives and Baudrillard’s argument against rational truth and morality of Enlightenment thinking. Such metanarratives represent grand ideals such as quests for knowledge for the sake of knowledge (as in German idealism) and for the production of knowledge as emancipatory for the people (Lechte, 1994). Lyotard’s critique forms a basis for postmodern critiques of singular, dominating goals for knowledge. Rather than

being valid representations of life, metanarratives or grand narratives instead fall into what Wittgenstein called language games, which, according to Lyotard, both point to the discursive construction of knowledge and create an openness to the multiplicities in understandings and their performance.

Non-universality: A postmodern lens and attitude in education spans a disciplinary level, leading to cross-disciplinary endeavors and collaborations that aim not to cut off particular disciplines, or ideals in education, but rather to build on them. Evident in Heidegger's and Habermas's work on the "incomplete project of modernity" (West, 2010, p. 238) the non-universality of postmodernism emphasizes also the political act implied in Levinas's responsibility toward otherness. Postmodern questioning of universalizing theories of development, learning, teaching, and educational futures open the way for collective meaning making, advancement, and cultural recognitions, rather than the dominant neoliberal focus of the 21st century (Kelsey, 2015).

Skepticism: In postmodernism skepticism is evident as a mistrust that grew from the resistance to the singularity of a modernist view. Postmodern skepticism represents the shift to an attitude of questioning epistemological and ontological certainties, taken-for-granted knowledge, or claims to knowledge (McQueen & McQueen, 2010). An example of postmodern skepticism is Kristeva's critique of the identity crises arising out of the horrors of war, colonization, and Hiroshima (Lechte, 1994).

Social construction: Also called social constructionism or social constructivism, social constructions of knowledge, meaning, or truths reflect a postmodern openness to diverse and unpredictable views by recognizing that they are shaped by or in or as a result of human engagements. In relation to education, the notion that learning occurs through social interactions, and that learning outcomes are co-constructed, supports the critique of expectations of uniform, predetermined truths or ways of knowing or being.

Uncertainty: The uncertainty of a postmodern lens—what Bauman (2009) calls the fluidity—reflects a situation where values, truths, validity, and rational thought become vague, where knowledge becomes challenged, where what might previously have been considered certain now is not. While postmodernism does not reject philosophical arguments, it does create a state of openness to multiplicities and diverse perspectives.

Key Figures in Postmodernism in Education

In this section three key figures of postmodernism relevant to the philosophy of education, are addressed, starting with Michel Foucault.

Michel Foucault: Postmodernism of Education

James Marshall (1987, p. 24) suggests

it must be a matter of concern that teacher trainees are not exposed sufficiently to a philosophy of education that would both enable them to make wise judgements on matters educational, but also to know and understand better the structures in which their professional activities are embedded, and the social roles which they perform.

For this training, Michel Foucault has much to offer. Foucault's study of disciplinary institutions informs a poststructural exploration of education. The production of the modern, but arguably any "educated," subject is a complex discursive project configured by intersecting institutions within a sociopolitical apparatus. Foucault tracks the modern manifestation of this project to the Delphic maxim regarding knowledge of self, a relationship that he contrasts to the care of the self. Foucault's work takes up the educational problem of knowledge "as an object of thought" with particular attention to questions concerning the meaning, conditions, and goals of knowledge (Foucault, 1994a, p. 117). Foucault developed his work from an archaeology of knowledge and knowledge practices to a genealogy of knowledge and knowledge practices within social and political contexts and traditions. Through Foucault the philosophy of education engages with the "technologies" and "biopolitics" of power and knowledge (1994b). Notably, through Foucault power and knowledge are explored for their inseparability within specific contexts and conditions and manifest in specific forms (Dreyfus & Rabinow, 1983, p. 129).

Power relations are extremely widespread in human relationships. Now, this means not that political power is everywhere, but that there is in human relationships a whole range of power relations that may come into play among individuals, within families, in pedagogical relationships, political life, and so on. . . . When an individual or social group succeeds in blocking a field of power relations, immobilizing them and preventing any reversibility of movement by economic, political, or military means, one is faced with what may be called a state of domination.

(Foucault, 1994c, p. 283)

Educational institutions and systems contribute to a particular knowledge about and the organization of individuals and communities. The educated subject, produced through these institutions and systems, is positioned as a subject that knows and manages their body, thought, and relationships (Peters & Marshall, 1996). For example, the age of public school enrollment, the structures of the classroom and the day, the knowledge that is taught and tested, and the progress that is rewarded all contribute to the learner's subjectivity within an educational institution.

Through Foucault, a government rationality, or governmentality, focuses the philosophy of education on these conditions and experiences. A rationality of government means "a way or system of thinking about the nature of the practice of government (who can govern; what governing is; what or who is governed), capable of making some form of that activity thinkable and practicable both to its practitioners and to those upon who it is practised" (Gordon, 1991, p. 3). Analysis of an education system explores, for instance, the ways in which a governmentality produces an educated subject and the features or characteristics of that subject. The contemporary subject of liberal and neoliberal governmentality, for example, is produced with a particular formulation of the self-managing learner in mind and, critically, in body (Peters, 1996).

Disciplines of observation, classification, and regulation are essential mechanisms for the legitimacy of the subject's production through education. For example, children are observed and classified in their play. The nature of their experiences is then associated with measurements of predetermined developmental outcomes and educational aims. Educational institutions are then designed with the aim of maximizing the efficiency of play—determining an orthodoxy of play spaces; play behaviors, relationships, and authorities; and play measurement, as well as the distribution and management of each of these roles (Foucault, 1991). The Foucauldian concept of “technologies of self” guides philosophical exploration of the teacher's and learner's acceptance and performance of a particular kind of playing self as an educational truth that emerges as a concern of government. The role of government is then to deploy its resources in the normalization of a particular truth (Walkerline, 1988).

The institutional technologies designed with a particular educated subject in mind are, for Foucault, never total in their production and domination of individuals and communities. The micro-practices of individuals confound the institutional mechanisms put in place to produce the individual. Freedom, as a central concern for Foucault (Marshall, 2001), is a practice made possible both as a governed truth and as the always present limits of governance. Through Foucault, a recognition of these limits, and of their particularity to any configuration of traditions, ideologies, and social organizations, presents the possibility of freedom and an openness to difference (Marshall, 2001). Walkerline (1988, p. 5) explains: “The post-structuralist work of Foucault allows us to engage with the production of sign systems, not as universal, trans-historical systems, but as specific historically generated bodies of knowledge. Not only that, but modern scientific accounts . . . can be understood as implemented in the production of our modern form of government—the democratic government of reason including ‘knowledges’ about children which claim to tell the truth about child development” and about the education of the child.

Jean-François Lyotard: Postmodernism of Education

Jean-François Lyotard's *The Postmodern Condition: A Report on Knowledge* (1999) traces the development of particular manifestations of knowledge in societal contexts and the ways in which those manifestations generate and justify universal theories and norms (Lyotard, 1999; Peters, 1997). Through Lyotard's work, the philosophy of education has produced critiques of grand narratives and explored both the experience and the role of education within the context of a crisis of legitimation. For instance, when an economic rationalism determines investment in and outputs of education systems, particular truths about the nature and purpose of education are entrenched into educational systems. Those systems are themselves the products of enduring narratives regarding truths of childhood and adulthood and of child development. Lyotard (1999, p. 19) says:

The very idea of development presupposes a horizon of nondevelopment where, it is assumed, the various areas of competence remain enveloped in the unity of a tradition and are not differentiated according to separate qualifications subject to specific innovation, debates and inquiries.

Lyotard explains the postmodern condition in terms of an incredulity to grand or metanarratives that has been unleashed in an age of computational systems. Computation prescribes the limits of possible knowledge statements and relationships (Lyotard, 1999). Education systems working

within those limitations are deployed to maintain the “hegemony” of computation—a hegemony revealed in clichés, including the information society and knowledge economy. While information technologies provide something of a catalyst for a postmodern turn, such technologies and systems are also entrenched in enduring narratives regarding education. For instance, a modern will to rationalize the world through an objective scientific rationality abides in educational institutions.

The modern will to rationalize has as its goal the maintenance of a universal system through which knowledge can be defined and measured. This commensurability syndrome is challenged by Lyotard in his analysis of the incommensurability of language games and the determination of authority over the rules of difference (Burbules, 2000). For instance, to claim that an education system has justly failed students who have not measured up to the standards established by the school system establishes that no appeal can be made by a student or community regarding the determination of what is valued, what is taught, how it is taught, and how it is measured.

Through Lyotard the philosophy of education recognizes the intentional centering of particular ways of thinking about knowledge and education and the decentering of others (Peters, 1999). Trajectories and rationalities of colonization through education are then an object of concern throughout Lyotard’s work.

“Who decides the conditions of truth?” It is recognized that the conditions of truth, in other words, the rules of the game of science, are immanent in that game, that they can only be established within the bounds of a debate that is already scientific in nature, and that there is no other proof that the rules are good than the consensus extended to them by the experts.

(Lyotard, 1999, p. 29)

The philosophical impetus in detailing and challenging colonizations of knowledge cannot, through Lyotard, appeal to universal truth. Through Lyotard’s thinking on the “differend,” education discourses are always positioned in incommensurable relationships—there is no singular grand narrative through which to determine the legitimacy of one pedagogical or developmental or educational theory.

Jacques Derrida: Postmodernism of Education

Derrida’s writing on and through deconstruction opens up philosophical work in education with regards to the language of the subject, the relationship between that which is positioned through language, and that which is responsible for the positioning of the subject through its necessary omission. In his writing on deconstruction, Derrida

attempts to disrupt understandings of human action that retain a strong elective affinity with values of mastery, sovereignty, and possession. The broader significance of this argument is, then, that established ways of thinking about the relational encounter between Self and Other—in terms of dialogical, reciprocal, dialectical, or symmetrical relations of co-implication—might actually obstruct rather than advance the cultivation of ethical responses to otherness.

(Barnett, 2005, p. 12)

Derrida takes up the production of, and impossibility of, a sovereign subject, a subject through deconstruction (Gregoriou, 2003; Senatore, 2011) with particular attention to the impossibility of hospitality (Derrida, 2000). His attention to sovereignty opens up philosophical questions concerning the myriad dimensions of authority that establish the legitimacy of the classroom, the school, and the curriculum and condemn that which is illegitimate within borders of education systems. Deconstruction is explained as neither method nor instrument for determining a more effective or efficient or better system (Vismann, 2005). Rather, through Derrida's concern with metaphysical universals, deconstruction troubles the production of unreflexive and decontextualized educational systems and practices that generate violent educational movements and that position their own relevance through the obscuring of difference (Derrida, 2002). Derrida's work provides clues to an escape from educational "scientificity" and the established currencies of "technoscientific objectivity" (Derrida, 1991, p. 60) and techno-deterministic educational systems:

This system is the teleological outcome of all of Western experience, so that in the end Hegel, the individual, is nothing but an empirical shell which can fall away without subtracting from the truth or from the history of meaning.

(Derrida, 1985b, p. 56)

In tracing and understanding the positioning of the rational and economic subject to be educated as the only valued subject (Peters & Burbules, 2004), Derrida engages with Cartesian, Hegelian, and Marxist subjects and problematizes the fixing of a singular subject through deconstruction. He develops "a science of writing which both deconstructs and moves beyond 'man' as the full presence of consciousness in being" (Peters, 2004, p. 62). Derrida (2000, p. 200) argues for caring about "the question of Being" (Derrida, 1991, p. 67) that is evident in the paradox of the authoring of the subject. Nietzsche

advances behind a plurality of masks or names that, like any mask and even any theory of the simulacrum, can propose and produce themselves only by returning a constant yield of protection, a surplus value in which one may still recognize the ruse of life.

(Derrida, 1985b, p. 7)

In this way Derrida takes up a poetic and playful approach to the problem of education. There is a play of hope to explore in the story of each function of education systems, from the autobiographical stories of the "founders" of received wisdom, to the stories that a teacher curates and disseminates in their attempts to transmit educational dogma and cliché into the more or less welcome mind and body of the learner, to the dawning of an awareness in the learner that only some forms, appearances, and ethics of learning are welcome in education institutions. Derrida (1985a) explains:

One could demonstrate that every time a philosophy and science claims to have constituted its own coherence in some fashion, it has in fact been led to reduce the element of play or to comprehend it by assigning it a place, to hem it in somehow. . . . In order to make apparent a play that is not comprehended in this philosophical or scientific space, one must think of play in another way.

(Derrida, 1985a, p. 69)

Conclusion: Toward the Future of Postmodernism

While postmodernism may now be considered to have been overtaken by other “posts”—post-qualitative, post-truth, post-digital—it still remains an important part of contemporary philosophy of education scholarship and indeed broader understandings and conceptualizations of education. It is possible to see the continuation of postmodern thinking and ideas in educational debates and trends while simultaneously experiencing their curtailment.

Postmodernism, undoubtedly, has played a significant role in what sometimes is termed the equity approach in education. Such an approach foregrounds the diversity of perspectives, cultures, knowledge, and experiences that inform and make up educational systems. Central to such an approach are questions of social justice and Indigenous epistemology and ontologies and their place in educational systems. However, counteracting this approach is the neoliberal educational agenda, which rejects the pluralism and diversity of postmodernism and instead resorts to binary thinking, standardization, and uncritical narratives. When considering the future or futures of postmodernism in education and the philosophy of education, it is worthwhile considering how these two influence each other. In the 21st century, educational policies and practice play a substantial role in shaping the philosophy of education, often providing a context to which scholars and thinkers react against. However, at other times, it is the philosophy of education that influences and helps shape educational policy and practice. It is possible to see this bidirectional relationship in relation to postmodernism since the 1960s, and one can only assume that such an interplay is likely to continue to drive the futures of postmodernism.

Further Reading

Heartney, E. (2001). *Postmodernism: Movements in modern art*. Cambridge University Press.

Hutcheon, L. (1988). *A poetics of postmodernism: History, theory, fiction*. Routledge.

Jameson, F. (1989). *Postmodernism, or, the cultural logic of late capitalism*. Duke University Press.

Kristeva, J. (1998). *Intimate revolt: The powers and limits of psychoanalysis* (J. Herman, Trans.). Columbia University Press.

McHale, B. (1992). *Constructing postmodernism*. Routledge.

Papastephanou, M., Zembylas, M., Bostad, I., Oral, S. B., Drousioti, K., Kouppanou, A., Strand, T., Wain, K., Peters, M. A., & Tesar, M. (2020). Philosophy of education in a new key: Education for justice now <https://doi.org/10.1080/00131857.2020.1793539>. *Educational Philosophy and Theory*, 1–16.

Smith, L. T. (1999). *Decolonizing methodologies: Research and Indigenous peoples*. Zed Books.

Weedon, C. (1997). *Feminist practice and poststructuralist theory*. Blackwell.

References

- Barnett, C. (2005). Ways of relating: Hospitality and the acknowledgement of otherness. *Progress in Human Geography*, 29(1), 5–21.
- Bauman, Z. (1991). *Modernity and ambivalence*. Polity Press.
- Bauman, Z. (2009). Education in the liquid-modern setting <<https://doi.org/10.2304/power.2009.1.2.157>>. *Power and Education*, 1(2), 157–166.
- Best, S., & Kellner, D. (1991). *Postmodern theory: Critical interrogations*. Palgrave Macmillan.
- Bochner, M. (2008). *Solar system & rest rooms: Writings and interviews 1965–2007*. MIT Press.
- Burbules, N. C. (2000). Lyotard on Wittgenstein: The differend, language games, and education. In P. Standish & P. Dhillon (Eds.), *Lyotard: Just education* (pp. 1–22). Taylor & Frances.
- Burbules, N. C. (2010). Postmodernism and education. In H. Siegel (Ed.), *The Oxford handbook of philosophy of education*. Oxford University Press.
- Dahlberg, G., Moss, P., & Pence, A. (2013). *Beyond quality in early childhood education and care*. Routledge.
- Deleuze, G., & Guattari, F. (2013). *A thousand plateaus: Capitalism and schizophrenia* (B. Massumi, Trans.). Bloomsbury Academic.
- Derrida, J. (1978). *Structure, sign and play*. University of Chicago Press.
- Derrida, J. (1985a). Roundtable on autobiography (P. Kamuf, Trans.). In C. V. McDonald (Ed.), *The ear of the other: Otobiography, transference, translation* (pp. 39–89). Schocken Books.
- Derrida, J. (1985b). Otobiographies: The teaching of Nietzsche and the politics of the proper name (A. Ronell, Trans.). In C. V. McDonald (Ed.), *The ear of the other: Otobiography, transference, translation* (pp. 1–38). Schocken Books.
- Derrida, J. (1991). *Of spirit: Heidegger and the question* (G. Bennington & R. Bowlby, Trans.). University of Chicago Press.
- Derrida, J. (2000). Hostipitality. *Angelaki*, 5(3), 3–18.
- Derrida, J. (2002). Events? What events? (P. Kamuf, Trans.). In E. Rottenberg (Ed.), *Negotiations* (pp. 74–76). Stanford University Press.
- Dreyfus, H. L., & Rabinow, P. (1983). *Michel Foucault: Beyond structuralism and hermeneutics*. University of Chicago Press.
- Foucault, M. (1991). *Discipline and punish* (A. Sheridan, Trans.). Penguin Books.
- Foucault, M. (1994a). Polemics, politics, and problematizations (L. Davis, Trans.). In P. Rabinow (Ed.), *Ethics, subjectivity and truth* (Vol. 1, pp. 111–119). Penguin Books.
- Foucault, M. (1994b). The birth of biopolitics (R. Hurley, Trans.). In P. Rabinow (Ed.), *Ethics, subjectivity and truth* (Vol. 1, pp. 73–79). Penguin Books.
- Foucault, M. (1994c). The ethics of the concern of the self as a practice of freedom (P. Aranov, & D. McGrawth, Trans.). In P. Rabinow (Ed.), *Ethics, subjectivity and truth* (Vol. 1, pp. 281–301). Penguin Books.

- Gasparatou, R. (2018). Postmodernism, science education and the slippery slope to the epistemic crisis <https://doi.org/10.1080/00131857.2018.1462524>. *Educational Philosophy & Theory*, 50(14), 1412–1413.
- Gordon, C. (1991). Government rationality: An introduction. In G. Burchell, C. Gordon, & P. Miller (Eds.), *The Foucault effect: Studies in governmentality* (pp. 1–51). Harvester Wheatsheaf.
- Gregoriou, Z. (2003). Resisting the pedagogical domestication of cosmopolitanism: From Nussbaum's concentric circles of humanity to Derrida's Aporetic ethics of hospitality. *Philosophy of Education*, 257–266.
- Huysen, A. (1986). *After the great divide: Modernism, mass culture, post-modernism*. Indiana University Press.
- Kelsey, J. (2015). *The FIRE economy: New Zealand's reckoning*. Bridget Williams Books.
- Lather, P. (1991). *Getting smart: Feminist research and pedagogy with/in the postmodern*. Routledge.
- Lather, P. (2017). *(Post)critical methodologies: The science possible after the critiques: The selected works of Patti Lather*. Routledge.
- Lechte, J. (1994). *Fifty key contemporary thinkers: From structuralism to postmodernity*. Routledge.
- Lipman, M. (2003) *Thinking in education* (2nd ed.). Cambridge University Press.
- Lyotard, J.-F. (1984). *The postmodern condition: A report on knowledge*. University of Minnesota Press.
- Lyotard, J.-F. (1999). *The postmodern condition: A report on knowledge* (G. Bennington & B. Massumi, Trans.). University of Minnesota Press.
- Marshall, J. D. (1987). *Positivism or pragmatism: Philosophy of education in New Zealand*. New Zealand Association for Research in Education.
- Marshall, J. D. (2001). A critical theory of the self: Wittgenstein, Nietzsche, Foucault. *Studies in Philosophy and Education*, 20, 75–91.
- McQueen, P., & McQueen, H. (2010). *Key concepts in philosophy*. Palgrave MacMillan.
- Peters, M. (2011). *The last book of postmodernism : Apocalyptic thinking, philosophy and education in the twenty-first century*. Peter Lang.
- Peters, M. A. (1996). *Poststructuralism, politics, and education*. Bergin and Garvey.
- Peters, M. A. (1997). Nietzsche, poststructuralism and education: After the subject? *Educational Philosophy and Theory*, 29(1), 1–19.
- Peters, M. A. (1999). *(Posts-) Modernism and structuralism: Affinities and theoretical innovations*. University of Auckland.
- Peters, M. A. (2004). Derrida, pedagogy and the calculation of the subject. In P. Trifonas & M. A. Peters (Eds.), *Derrida, deconstruction and education* (pp. 59–77). Blackwell.
- Peters, M. A., & Burbules, N. C. (2004). *Poststructuralism and educational research*. Rowman & Littlefield.
- Peters, M. A., & Marshall, J. D. (1996). *Individualism and community: Education and social policy in the postmodern condition*. Falmer Press.

Peters, M. A., Tesar, M., & Jackson, L. (2018). After postmodernism in educational theory? A collective writing experiment and thought survey <<https://doi.org/10.1080/00131857.2018.1457868>>. *Educational Philosophy and Theory*, 50(14), 1299–1307.

Peters, M. A., Tesar, M., Jackson, L., & Besley, T. (2020). *After postmodernism in educational theory?* Routledge.

Senatore, M. (2011). In the name of the event: The deconstructive conjuration. *Parallax*, 17(1), 43–53.

Stewart, G., Arndt, S., Besley, T., Devine, N., Forster, D. J., Gibbons, A., Grierson, E., Jackson, L., Jandrić, P., Locke, K., Peters, M. A., & Tesar, M. (2017). Antipodean theory for educational research <<https://doi.org/10.1080/23265507.2017.1337555>>. *Open Review of Educational Research*, 4(1), 61–74.

Tesar, M. (2020). Philosophy as a method: Tracing the histories of intersections of “philosophy,” “methodology” and “education.” <<https://doi.org/10.1177/1077800420934144>> *Qualitative Inquiry*.

Tesar, M. (2021). Some thoughts concerning post-qualitative methodologies <<https://doi.org/10.1177/1077800420931141>>. *Qualitative Inquiry*, 27(2), 223–227.

Tesar, M., & Arndt, S. (2019). Philosophies and ethics of the project archive <<https://doi.org/10.1080/00131857.2018.1476237>>. *Educational Philosophy and Theory*, 51(4), 434–444.

Usher, R., & Edwards, R. (1994). *Postmodernism and education*. Routledge.

Vismann, C. (2005). Derrida, philosopher of the law. *German Law Journal*, 6(1), 5–13.

Walkerdine, V. (1988). *The mastery of reason: Cognitive development and the production of rationality*. Routledge.

West, D. (2010). *Continental philosophy* (2nd ed.). Polity Press.

Related Articles

Social Cartography in Educational Research

Poststructuralism and Educational Leadership and Administration

Dynamics of Decision Making